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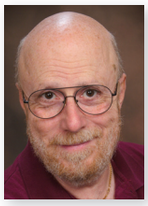
Turning small things

Kurt Hertzog looks at the equipment and processes required for turning on a small scale

KURT HERTZOG



Kurt is a professional woodturner, demonstrator and teacher and writes for various woodturning and woodworking publications in the United States as well as contributing to *Woodturning* magazine. He is on the Pen Makers' Guild Council and is past president of the American Association of Woodturners (AAW).

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I am very often asked the question about lathe size by those new to woodturning. I'm asked 'what size lathe should I buy?'. The answer of course depends on: what you intend to turn, not only now but into the future; how much space you have available; what is your budget; and more. The advice I usually give is to buy the biggest lathe you can within the space and budget available. You can always turn small items on a big lathe but not vice versa. Those who start their turning lives with smaller items, such as pens, bottle stoppers, lidded boxes and similar, almost always progress to larger items. In this issue, we'll focus on turning smaller items. For those who started with mid-sized or large turnings, we'll cover the key needs on various different-sized lathes and some of the important points you'll need to consider with small turnings. While you may not need a 660mm swing lathe to turn pens, you can certainly use this.

The key to turning smaller work on a lathe is to have the ability to hold the work safely and accurately and present the appropriately-sized tools, close enough and with good support. Often, the ability to get a tool rest in close and of a size that fits well is the stumbling block on larger equipment. We'll cover a variety of workholding devices that will be helpful but don't feel that you need bankrupt yourself at the woodturning supplier. Many workholding methods can be created in your own shop and sized specifically to your end goal. A review of the workholding series in *Woodturning* 235–250 may assist you. This series contains a wide variety of workholding fundamentals and techniques along with tips and tricks to help you solve your workholding problems.

Safety

Just because you may be turning things that aren't terribly large doesn't mean you can slack on safety. Your eye and breathing protection are still imperative as small debris and the sanding dust can be just as harmful as larger debris. You need to have your appropriate PPE in place regardless of the size of your turning. Complacency in the workshop is responsible for far more accidents and injuries than currently get reported and publicised.

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